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Co-producing the right to fail: resilient grassroots cooperativism in a Chilean informal settlement

‘Ever tried. Ever failed. No matter. Try again. Fail again. Fail better’

Samuel Beckett, ‘Worstward Ho’

‘Elegir nos hace libres, elegir nos hace fuertes’
(Choosing makes us free, choosing makes us strong)

Skimi, ‘Como átomos’

The article depicts how the inhabitants of the *macrocampamento* (macro-slum) ‘Los Arenales’ aimed to bring their concrete urban utopia closer, by co-producing the first cooperative bakery in a Chilean informal settlement. Despite its many flaws, the process is proposed as a social innovation, since it managed to bring a new diverse economy into existence while also improving several aspects of the urban displaced. It is also novel in gathering historically disjointed actors, such as the campamento’s inhabitants, local NGOs, academia and the state, especially rare considering the Chilean neoliberal context. The experimental nature of the process and inexperience of the actors involved led to several failures. But it also co-produced unexpected outcomes, such as increased resilience, empowerment and broader/stronger networks for the campamentos’ inhabitants, highlighting the importance of the right to fail. The experience is presented through an engaged research approach, raising some critical assessments of each actor’s participation and valuable lessons for similar endeavours.

Keywords: cooperativism, co-production, informal settlements, social innovation, grassroots resilience, Chile, campamento, diverse economies, slums, grassroots empowerment

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Introduction

The opening quote from Nobel Prize winner Samuel Beckett has been frequently used by influential entrepreneurs and self-help gurus to highlight the idea that success lies in better failures. However, Beckett was not known for his optimism but for being a rather bleak and darkly humorous author. A pessimistic reading is that after each failure, only further failure awaits, while other – less gloomy – interpretations draw attention to a message of existential resistance, of the need to keep moving forward no matter what. The experience analysed here somehow incorporates all of these, specifically regarding the multi-actor process of co-producing the first cooperative bakery in an informal Chilean settlement, known as a *campamento* (Ojeda et al., 2018).

The second quote is not as famous (yet) and comes from Skimi, a young rapper and artist from the *macrocampamento* Los Arenales;¹ the largest conglomerate of campamentos in the city of Antofagasta, Chile, known worldwide for its outstanding mineral wealth and macroeconomic growth (Arias et al., 2014; OECD, 2013; Phelps et al., 2015). As a promised land of mining-related jobs, Antofagasta has attracted Latin American immigrants who aspire to get better wages and living conditions (Rodrigo-Benito, 2010). However, the city also faces a steady increase in the cost of living, especially related to housing (Vergara-Perucich and Boano, 2019); relatively low wages; and high unemployment rates (Durán and Kremerman, 2019). These factors have forced immigrant workers to settle in informal settlements (MINVU, 2019), exposed to a multi-layered stigmatisation characterised by social exclusion, xenophobia and aporophobia (Cortina, 2017; Tijoux, 2016; Tijoux and Díaz, 2014).

As a migrant herself, Skimi's art represents the struggle of the people of Los Arenales for their right to the city. Under the motto 'por la casa, por un techo, la vivienda es un derecho',² these dwellers struggle to overcome their extreme precarity through collective organisation and self-sufficiency. They do not want to be passive receivers of top-down solutions, but to build their urban space by developing new means of production. Skimi's lyrics encapsulate their aspirations when she sings that choosing makes them free, stronger and eager to learn, experiment and overcome any setbacks.

In 2017, some community members of Los Arenales chose to start the first cooperative bakery in Chile, the birthplace of neoliberalism (Harvey, 2005; Klein, 2007).³ This was an experimental multi-actor effort which may be understood as a social innovation process for co-producing a novel form of diverse economy (Bell and Pahl, 2018; Gibson-Graham, 2008), where several disjointed local, national and international actors came together in an extremely unlikely alliance, involving macrocampamento

1 A macrocampamento is a category of slum; and Los Arenales literally means 'the sandy place'.

2 In English: For a house, for a roof, [access to affordable] housing is a [human] right.

3 Understood as an ideology and political economic practice within free market economic systems, positing that well-being can be best achieved by fostering private ownership, an individualistic ethos and the reduction of the state to its minimum functions.

mento's inhabitants, local and international NGOs, the state and academia (Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019).

This article's objective is to describe and assess the turbulent but inspiring process of failing, trying again, and failing a bit better in co-producing the bakery named Cooperativa Intercultural de Trabajo CINTRA Los Arenales.⁴ Against all odds, the process managed to co-produce a symbolic and elemental product, bread (Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019) and to deliver valuable lessons regarding how to implement experimental and cooperative modes of production from informality, based on solidarity, self-sufficiency, resilience and urban social justice (Bell and Pahl, 2018; Mitlin, 2008).

As depicted in Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola (2019), the process was permeated by the 'right to the city agenda', communal thinking of the *concrete utopia* approach, meaning the multi-actor efforts and plans to advance from solidary reflections to their actual realisation (Lefebvre, 1968). The bakery faced internal and external frictions but, despite those challenges, it ignited a process where Los Arenales' inhabitants were empowered by solidifying its inner interactions, expanded their networks, fostered a more favourable public opinion towards the *campamentos*, learned from the mistakes and facilitated new chances for co-producing valuable inputs for bargaining with the Chilean state.

The experimental nature of the project, despite its flaws, led to several unexpected outcomes, such as improved solidarity, empowerment and resilience. This accentuates the critical importance of *the right to fail*, to keep trying, and fail better. By overcoming difficulties, the group also co-created mutual trust and a solid feeling of commitment to the success of the bakery. This is one of the most innovative aspects of the experience and findings.

An exemplary consequence of those newly developed, multi-actor relations and organisational capabilities was that the funding by the Slum Dwellers International NGO in Chile for the first Know Your City project was awarded to Los Arenales, Rompiendo Barreras in 2018.⁵ This led to co-producing primary data used in their bargaining with the state to achieve their desired *radicación* gaining local and national notoriety.⁶ These experiences strengthened the possibility of their being recognised as part of the city while becoming a reference for innovation, organised solidarity and resilience for other *campamentos*.

The article is structured as follows: First, it discusses the co-production of a diverse economy based on cooperation, solidarity and self-sufficiency. Second, the methodologies of engaged research and empirical data are detailed; Third, it presents the context of the bakery. Fourth, it describes how the bakery project began. Fifth, it analyses the process and provides learning for future endeavours focused on fostering urban social justice. Finally, the article summarises the main conclusions and reflections.

4 In English: Intercultural Work Cooperative CINTRA The Sandy Place.

5 Referred to as *campamento's* inhabitants from here.

6 *Radicación* means being able to 'settle down' in the territory they currently occupy.

The social innovation of co-producing a diverse economy in an informal settlement

There is well-established literature about experimental social innovations led by impoverished grassroots communities to find novel and sustainable forms of social justice. This article assesses the struggle experienced by a group of slum dwellers in their creation of a self-sufficient, concrete utopia of their choosing, based on a similar strategy, but more politically engaged with the aims of the community rather than individuals (Lefebvre, 1968; Purcell, 2002; Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019). This meant diversifying the local economy from a purely capitalistic standpoint focused on large-scale mining exploitation by introducing the first cooperative bakery in a Chilean *macrocampamento* (Gibson-Graham, 2008; Gibson-Graham et al., 2013). To do this, the community reached out to a local NGO, the state and academics, all of which participated in co-creating the bakery, thus learning substantially from the process (Bell and Pahl, 2018; Mitlin, 2008; 2018; Ojeda et al., 2018). This section briefly summarises the theoretical framework to reflect on how this bakery contributes to knowledge.

Social innovations for better futures

For some, the concept of social innovation is considered a ‘buzz word’ or ‘plastic concept’, void of any real meaning (Van der Laan, 2001). Nonetheless, it could be useful for describing the implementation of experimental new ideas with the capacity to spark cultural, normative or regulative changes, reinforce a society’s collective power and improve its economic outcomes, social performance and resilience. The concept also implies efforts to bring society closer to a utopic future (Heiskala, 2007; Pol and Ville, 2009). To concretise that utopia, *social* innovations focus on improving the quality and/or the quantity of life, putting human welfare in the spotlight, whereas the other kind, *business* innovations, only focus on increasing the firm’s profits (Pol and Ville, 2009).

Consequently, a desirable social innovation is an original and socially implemented idea that presents convincing evidence about improving the macro-quality of life. They should increase the number of beneficial options available to them in terms of living, working and political and environmental (among others) conditions made available through market/non-market mechanisms. In this sense, social innovations fit better with collective forms of production (Pol and Ville, 2009).

Social innovations could be crucial in assessing some burning socio-economic issues, especially related to extreme concentration of wealth and outdated visions of eternal economic growth. Those issues might threaten socio-economic ecosystems and foster the displacement of people to informal urban spaces, feeding the possibility

of the concrete dystopia of a ‘planet of slums’ (Davis, 2006). Free market economies, especially in the global South, show many (if not all) of the previous features, which are perceived as market failures (Desai and Loftus, 2013).

The widening socio-economic inequalities have induced the proliferation of a ‘plethora of hidden and alternative economic activities’ as a survival strategy. Those informal, marginal and diverse economic activities are globally widespread and more prevalent than capitalistic practices (Gibson-Graham, 2008, 6). They can be highly experimental, which may involve several failed attempts before succeeding. If so, the innovation may also have a substantial impact on social, material and environmental well-being if they rise from a socially engaged origin and look to increase the number of jobs and added value they produce in a solidary and sustainable manner (Ironmonger, 1996; Schneider and Enste, 2013).

In extreme free market contexts where capitalistic forms of production are the norm, the apparition of informal economic activities based on an ethos of solidarity and cooperative principles can become social innovations. If they endure, the economic activities taking place in a territory expand, hosting not just capitalistic, but wide and disparate forms of economies (Gibson-Graham et al., 2013). Because of their potential, those socially innovative economic practices have been studied by the diverse economy framework, which claims they should be recognised, nourished and researched, facilitating their consideration as more real and ‘viable objects of policy and activism’ (Gibson-Graham, 2008, 618).

The diverse economy of cooperatives

A diverse economy serves as an adjective for socio-economic systems with different kinds of firms, but is also an academic approach for illustrating the immense variety of capitalistic or non-capitalistic economic activities taking place in a community, region or nation. Although not without detractors (see Samers, 2005), the framework characterises an economy according to five variables: labour practices (wage, alternative paid, unpaid), business enterprises (capitalist, alternative capitalist, non-capitalist), transactions of goods and services (market, alternative market, open access), property ownership (private, alternative private, open access), and finance (mainstream market, alternative market, non-market) (Gibson-Graham, 2008; Gibson-Graham et al., 2013).

Similarly to the concrete utopia (Lefebvre, 1968; Purcell, 2002), the diverse economy approach is also a ‘performative ontological project’; both encourage attempts to bring new socio-economic urban landscapes into existence, especially those aiming to improve the quality of life in collaborative and communal efforts (Gibson-Graham, 2008, 616). When successful, community economies rise as network spaces where inter-dependent relations are democratically agreed upon by the participating actors and institutions. Since they can be created at any scale, they could advance the concrete

communal construction of better living socio-economic habitats (Gibson-Graham et al., 2013; Lefebvre, 1968). However, projects promoting socio-economic autonomy and community empowerment through experimentation are likely to face repeated failure. Even though failure can happen for plenty of reasons, if the group keeps learning and persevering, their resilience will be awarded better chances of success.

The diverse economy approach recognises cooperatives and informal settlements as examples of non-capitalistic economies, since they are organised around an ethos of solidarity, have an alternatively paid labour, and distribute their profits between their members and wider community, according to democratic negotiations between all the participating actors (Gibson-Graham, 2008; Gibson-Graham et al., 2013; Roelvink et al., 2015). Building these community economies is crucial for empowering grassroots movements since they could promote further social and productive innovation processes to transform and achieve social justice, despite starkly unequal power structures (Muller and Mitlin, 2007; Smith et al., 2014).

Cooperatives have also become essential providers of jobs worldwide. According to a report made by CICOPA (Eum, 2017), employment in or within the scope of cooperatives represents at least 279.4 million people across 156 countries, a staggering 9.46 per cent of the total employed population worldwide. Cooperatives are especially prevalent in some Latin American countries' history, such as Argentina, Bolivia and Brazil (Birchall, 1997; 2011; Magni and Günther, 2014); although Chile only has 0.13 per cent of its workforce participating in cooperatives (Unidad de Estudios Ministerio de Economía, 2014). They are acknowledged as relevant in dealing with informality, particularly by the ILO recommendation number 193, which posits that:

Governments should promote the important role of cooperatives in transforming what are often marginal survival activities (sometimes referred to as the 'informal economy') into legally protected work, fully integrated into mainstream economic life'. (ILO, 2002)

Creating a cooperative might be extremely challenging for the urban displaced, especially within a neoliberal context. However, by avoiding conventional top-down state-driven solutions, grassroots-led cooperatives can focus on promoting economic self-sufficiency, horizontal comradeship and political and civic empowerment (Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019). All cooperatives have the political objective of fostering their informal dwellers' incorporation in the formal city through the recognition of rights, instead of just being subjects of charity by states and NGOs. Grassroots-led cooperatives might then foster 'new forms of social power emerging within [a] slum of the Global South' (Desai and Loftus, 2013, 795), to contest (dis)empowerment strategies that they face daily, such as their demonisation, marginalisation and exclusion (Mitlin and Bartlett, 2018). Yet, this puts them on a collision course with the actors comfortable with how power is (a)symmetrically distributed in the urban landscape (McFarlane, 2012; Mitlin, 2008; 2018).

Nonetheless, bringing those economies into existence can be challenging, especially in informal and stigmatised contexts with few support networks. Therefore, the diverse economies approach emphasises the decisive role that social actors and institutions like academia, civil society, grassroots communities and the state should play in cooperatives' co-creation and consolidation.

Multi-actor co-production for and with the urban poor

To challenge the negative perceptions of the urban poor and overcome their socio-economic vulnerability, multi-actor co-production processes have been extremely useful. Mitlin and Bartlett (2018) summarise that engagement arising from co-production provides opportunities to dispute these views by raising the socio-economic status of low-income residents. Co-production is understood, then, as processes of material improvement and knowledge as well as capacity and relationship creation. Through these, social movements take shape, and their agendas are advanced in a multi-actor effort (Mitlin and Bartlett, 2018). This builds upon the original definition by Whitaker (1980), where co-production was an explicit political strategy through which grassroots organisations and the state were able to jointly secure the satisfaction of basic needs while also strengthening civil society's bargaining position and direct participation. Hence, a co-production of a cooperative could simultaneously secure material welfare and promote the partial concretisation of utopic urban political projects.

Today, co-production might also emerge from other actors, such as NGOs and academia (Mitlin and Bartlett, 2018), in a process where actors work together horizontally, to overcome longstanding antagonisms and power asymmetries (Simon et al., 2018), and to advance social and urban justice by challenging the structures that reproduce inequalities (Castán and Neves, 2018). Hence, it disputes the notion that research should be done *on* disadvantaged groups, but *with* organised citizens instead, triggering a process of radical change (Mitlin, 2018; Mitlin and Bartlett, 2018).

For a long time, co-production was considered a strategy relevant in the presence of weak states, unable to provide basic services, guarantee human rights, and/or decent life conditions (Mitlin, 2008). Although not universally endorsed today (Mitlin, 2018), such a position is still useful for highly neoliberal contexts, where individualism is the norm. However, co-production efforts cannot be embraced uncritically. Such processes may be disempowering if: 1) There is a capture of benefits by the local elite; 2) new and/or complex responsibilities are passed to vulnerable groups (Castán and Neves, 2018); 3) the social innovation of horizontally organised arrangements of governance ends up reinforcing market-oriented behaviour, due to a failure in implementing democratic, participative and horizontally networked interdependencies (Swyngedouw, 2005).

When considering the above, grassroots, community-based cooperatives rising in extremely free market contexts can be considered a type of socially innovative approach to supporting self-sufficient economic strategies. This research considers the experimental multi-actor co-production of the first cooperative bakery in a Chilean macrocampamento as a project looking to promote a diverse economy and further social innovations with positive outcomes. Nonetheless, the project also triggered some contradictions that will be further developed throughout this article and its conclusions. The next section provides a brief discussion of the methods, which will later be used to describe and evaluate the overall experience.

Methodology

The case of the cooperative bakery is presented following an ‘explanation building’ (Yin, 2009), produced conjointly with key agents involved in the project. The description and analysis of the case study are illustrated from an engaged research stance. Engaged research implies a rigorous approach to produce a collaborative interaction *with* (and not at the cost of) a community. It is aimed at understanding and resolving issues and challenges of their interest *for* them). This entails contesting the assumption that researched subjects are mere ‘vessels that empty themselves into research indiscriminately’ (Blake, 2007, 414). However, they are considered active participants in evaluating social endeavours (Blake, 2007).

Engaged researchers worked in a close multi-actor partnership but kept a negotiated distance of intellectual autonomy by which to analyse the process critically (Ang, 2006). This way of co-producing knowledge usually implies establishing mutual reciprocity, long-term relationships, critical assessments of place-based human issues within broader ecosystems, the embracing of differences and positive conflict to produce knowledge and empowerment, and the acknowledgment of the ethical/practical repercussions of methodological decisions (Ang, 2006; Arvanitakis & Hodge, 2012; Magee et al., 2013).

By becoming directly engaged, the researchers were considered to be another key actor. Thus, they positioned themselves as ethically co-responsible for the successes and failures of the bakery and directly involved in co-producing useful and critical knowledge. There were several benefits to being engaged. For instance, there were plenty of resources available for the researchers to use in their description and understanding of the process. The project was further legitimised due to the participation of universities, the appearance of new opportunities to expand its original aims, and the fact that local academics got out of their perceived ‘ivory towers’ (Blake, 2007; Demko, 1988; Readings, 1996). Academic practices also comprised the production of several publications in local and national newspapers, something Hoffman (2019) considered to be ‘militant acts’ aimed at actively producing a broader political *we* between researchers and researched.

Primary data was gathered between 2017–2019, through observations, notes and six semi-structured interviews with key actors, representing the macrocampamento, the bakery (a representative and a cooperativist), the local government, a local NGO, and academia, all of whom were directly involved throughout the process. The interviews took place between January and July of 2019 – around a year after the formation of the bakery – to better capture a more critical and nuanced evaluation.

Positionality of the researchers

The authors were involved as observant participants, taking notes and collecting impressions. This engagement requires some clarifications about the positionality of researchers. Both are male, Chilean and formed on different approaches of critical theory to social sciences, in which the search for contradictions of social phenomena is key for producing knowledge. This implied some initial research bias, given that a more liberal framing of the problem was initially discarded as an analytical framework for the case. Both researchers lived in Antofagasta when the research was conducted, with direct involvement in the cultural context where Los Arenales exists. Hence, their engagement with the community also had political implications, given that this informal settlement is not transversally accepted by the local community of Antofagasta.

Nevertheless, the methods of analysis and data collection were developed under a strict code of ethical research framed by one of the funders of the investigation. Although the positionality of the researchers may have influenced their approach to the experience, the analysis and conclusions were carried out in a critical fashion, aiming to provide academic reflections of the process to be shared with a broader community. Next, the context where the bakery took place is described.

The rising tide of campamentos in Chile and Antofagasta

Chile is exceptionally famous and infamous worldwide, considering its small size. Among the positive, it has been praised for its economic and political stability, leading economic growth among OECD and Latin American states (OECD, 2013; World Bank, 2017). Its principal economic activity is mining, being the world's biggest producer of copper, iodine and lithium (USGS, 2018), mostly exploited in the Antofagasta region (see Figure 1) (Arias et al., 2014; Phelps et al., 2015). Infamously, Chile is the earliest and one of the most vigorous adopters of neoliberal economic policies worldwide (Harvey, 2005; Klein, 2007), brutally implemented during Pinochet's dictatorship (Constable and Valenzuela, 1993; Salazar and Pinto, 2002; Solimano, 2012), which fostered economic transformations mostly favouring its wealthiest citizens (Bohoslavsky et al., 2019).



Figure 1 Map of Chile, the Antofagasta region, its main cities and mining towns
Source: Phelps et al. (2015)

The widespread perception of Chile as an economic miracle hides the darkest side of its neoliberalism: extreme inequalities shaped by a concentration of political power and wealth, and increasing spatial segregation (Boano and Vergara-Perucich, 2017; Phelps et al., 2018). Today, Chile ranks as one of the most unequal nations among the OECD members (2016). However, the positive international perception led to an increasing immigration rate during the last decade, paired with a worrying escalation of racism and xenophobia (INDH, 2017; Tijoux and Díaz, 2014). Simultaneously, stagnant wages, relatively slow economic growth, increasing unemployment and housing costs have exponentially increased the number of families living in campamentos; especially since 2011, when the commodity super-cycle concluded (see Figure 2) (CIS TECHO-Chile, 2016; TECHO, 2018).

The Antofagasta region has also been considered an example due to its growth rates based on extractive industry exploitation (CEPAL, 2009; OCDE, 2009; OECD, 2013). Yet, its celebrated macroeconomic results have failed to produce fair socio-economic development, especially in its capital city, Antofagasta (Arias et al., 2014; Phelps et al., 2015). Two crucial challenges troubling the Antofagasta region stand out:

First, the relatively large international migration received in the last decade following the copper boom prices, as the immigration rate increased by 327 per cent between 2005 and 2014 (Departamento de Extranjería y Migración, 2016). Nowadays, around 11 per cent of the Antofagasta region's total population are foreign immigrants, coming largely from Colombia, Peru, and Bolivia (INE, 2017). Second, the increasing expulsion of part of the local labour force – especially immigrants – into *campamentos*, due to increasing housing prices (Contreras et al., 2019; López-Morales et al., 2018; Stang and Stefoni, 2016; Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019). The census of 2017 and CASEN 2015 (Encuesta de Caracterización Socioeconómica Nacional [National Socioeconomic Characterisation Survey]) estimate that around 12 per cent of the immigrant population in Antofagasta live in an impoverished situation, typically in *campamentos*. Between 2007 and 2018 alone there was a rampant 980 per cent increase in the number of families living in such informal settlements (TECHO, 2018).

The mix of these social issues has caused rising discrimination against the immigrants and the inhabitants of the *campamentos* of Antofagasta. Poor immigrants face racism and xenophobia daily, all of which weaken their own perception as subjects with rights (Guizardi et al., 2018; INDH, 2017; Stang and Stefoni, 2016; Tijoux, 2016; Tijoux and Díaz, 2014). Thus, they usually accept informal jobs with extremely low wages and precarious working conditions (Contreras et al., 2019; López-Morales et al., 2018; Stang and Stefoni, 2016; Stefoni, 2011). All these make developing sustainable ways for generating incomes and securing dignified living conditions extremely urgent.

Table 1 Families living in *campamentos* in Chile 2007–2018

Administrative region	2007	2018	Variation %
Arica y Parinacota	434	293	-32,49%
Tarapacá	1,604	3,935	145,32%
Antofagasta	632	6,831	980,85%
Atacama	1,921	3,365	75,17%
Coquimbo	679	635	-6,48%
Valparaíso	6,228	11,150	79,03%
O'Higgins	1,304	985	-24,46%
Maule	1,389	45	-96,76%
Biobío	4,888	7,460	52,62%
Araucanía	1,435	365	-74,56%
Los Ríos	1,067	692	-35,15%
Los Lagos	1,213	2,312	90,60%
Aysén	97	204	110,31%
Región Metropolitana	5,599	4,214	-24,74%
Total	28,490	42,486	49,13%

Source: Authors' own elaboration based on CIS TECHO-Chile (2016); TECHO (2018)

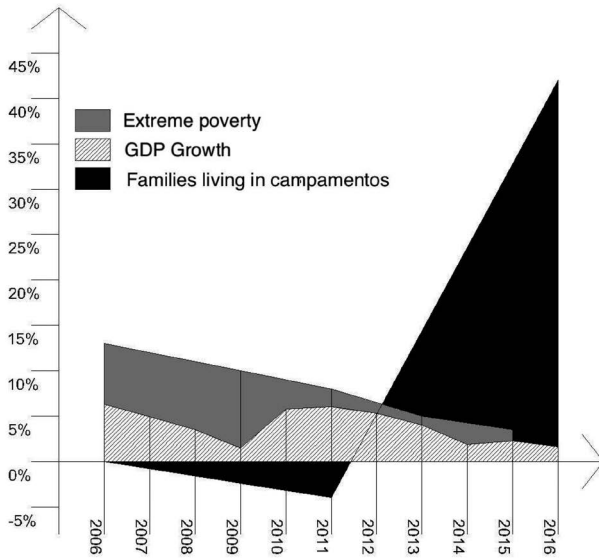


Figure 2 Relationship between extreme poverty, GDP growth and the growth rate of families living in *campamentos* using 2011 as a base

Source: Authors' own elaboration based on the Social Development Ministry, World Bank and TECHO

Amidst this context, the *macrocampamento* Los Arenales shows several key features. First, it is macro since it comprises at least ten different *campamentos* unified under a central board of democratically elected representatives named Rompiendo Barreras. Second, around 80 per cent of its inhabitants are immigrants from other Latin American countries (GORE, 2016). Third, despite its challenging internal complexity, size and mixed cultural backgrounds, the organisation has managed to produce a solid sense of belonging, respect and dignity (Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019).

Like most of the *campamentos* in Antofagasta, Los Arenales was constructed on the foothills of the city (Figure 3), using over 11.4 hectares of public land. The Chilean state is reluctant to allow the informal occupation of land by low-income families. It frequently uses the police to repress and evict – in an awfully violent way – (Handelman, 1975; Salcedo, 2010) or displace those families to ‘temporary camps’ located at the city’s fringe (Contreras et al., 2019). The topology of the terrain is irregular, arid and lacks facilities for living. Most of the houses are built with light material, and its internal frontiers are perfectly recognised by the inhabitants of each settlement. Los Arenales’s geopolitics and land management are based on collective forces that are organised horizontally in the organisation Los Arenales Rompiendo Barreras, leading to an extremely dynamic spatial development with new houses built every month. Despite these difficulties, the resilience, solidarity and will to improve their living conditions among the inhabitants of Los Arenales have fostered a continuous development of strategic projects such as the cooperative bakery detailed next.

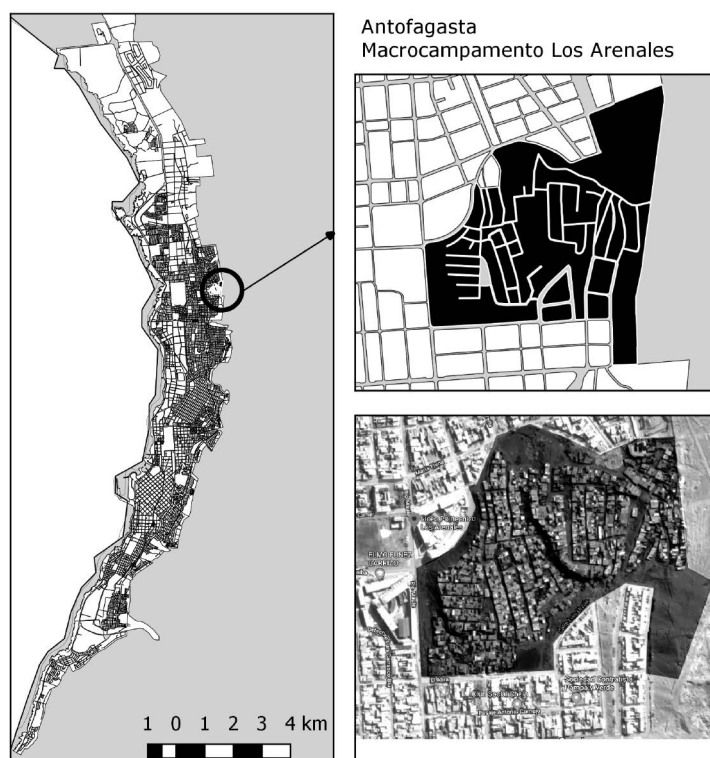


Figure 3 Map of the city of Antofagasta and the *macrocampamento* Los Arenales
Source: Authors' own elaboration based on Google Maps

The unlikely making of the first cooperative bakery

In a fortunate series of events, several actors came together in 2017 to participate in the co-creation of the first cooperative bakery in a Chilean campamento. This was unusual, considering that only 0.13 per cent of the regional workforce of Antofagasta participated in a cooperative (Unidad de Estudios Ministerio de Economía, 2014). If successful, this effort had the potential to become a social innovation and diversify the local economy, becoming an example of non-capitalistic production. The actors were the campamento dwellers, the Chilean government, a local NGO and the academia:

- 1) The most important actors were the inhabitants of the macrocampamento Los Arenales, politically organised in Los Arenales Rompiendo Barreras.⁷ Noticeably, Chilean shantytowns were powerful left-winged political actors before the dictatorship; but mass arrests, executions and selective relocations during that period starkly disempowered them (Handelman, 1975; Rodríguez and

7 In English: Breaking Chains.

Winchester, 2001). Hence, the recent resurgence of strong political associations like Rompiendo Barreras is especially relevant.

- 2) The government participated through the programme Funds for Solidarity and Social Investments (FOSIS), something novel since the dictatorship established a rather distant relationship between informal settlements and the state (Posner, 2012). FOSIS is part of the Social Development Ministry, and it has a national budget that is managed and targeted by the local government (Secretaría Regional Ministerial de Desarrollo Social). Consequently, FOSIS mostly avoids funding social investments in informal settlements.
- 3) Academia was represented by the Culinary School of Universidad Santo Tomás (UST) and three academics from the Observatorio Regional de Desarrollo Humano (ORDHUM) – part of the Universidad Católica del Norte (UCN) – where the authors belong. This was unusual since the highly marketised Chilean higher education system have a ‘publish or die’ attitude rather than any thought of working with and for the civil society (Guzmán-Valenzuela and Barnett, 2013; Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019).
- 4) All these actors were coordinated by the local NGO Agrupación de Trabajadores del Area Social FRACTAL (ATTAS-FRACTAL),⁸ well known for its work with *campamentos* and immigrants since 2012. Their work was pivotal for this initiative since they aimed to empower and articulate the *campamento*’s inhabitants’ long-term political struggle for a *radicación* and decent living, contrasting with the usual short-term provision of goods and services done by other NGOs.

The bakery started when FRACTAL undertook a project funded by FOSIS at the border between Los Arenales and the adjacent formal neighbourhood. The main goal of this project was to advance towards a more autonomous way of generating resources to improve the space where they live at, based on the community’s capabilities and learning new skills of self-sufficiency. In 2015, they opened La Casita (the Little House), a centre for working with children from the neighbourhood through several activities, especially sports. This became the main hub for laying the foundations of Los Arenales Rompiendo Barreras since, ‘La Casita united the campamento, [FRACTAL] gathered us and empowered us. [They] gave us a space to gather and [the] tools [...] and networks’ [Los Arenales representative]. That same year, FRACTAL carried out a series of workshops for the inhabitants of Los Arenales where they presented several democratic ways of production as, according to them:

The logic of individual entrepreneurship [promoted by the Chilean state] is oriented to failure. [It just exists to] reduce the poverty indexes instead of focusing on providing dignified living conditions [...] We told [the inhabitants of Los Arenales] that they should bet for collective entrepreneurship, preferably, cooperatives. (FRACTAL representative)

8 Referred to just as FRACTAL from here.

Several representatives of Los Arenales were paying close attention to those words.

During early 2017, the visit of the UN housing speaker Leilani Farha to Los Arenales, organised by Rompiendo Barreras and FRACTAL, was pivotal in promoting the interest of the macrocampamento in considering housing and access to the formal city as human rights, despite their status as poor foreigners (Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019). After her visit, Farha wrote a controversial open letter to President Bachelet, pushing the Chilean state to stop the discrimination towards campamentos by '[providing] the necessary legal framework and ensure access to resources to allow access to different types of tenure beyond ownership, for example cooperative housing, land trusts and other community ownership models (Farha, 2017, 18–19). The academics of the ORDHUM met with FRACTAL and Los Arenales Rompiendo Barreras, after Farha's visit, to establish a horizontal collaborative alliance between them and the macrocampamento. Five workshops related to the right of the city were agreed upon and took place during 2017, where academics stressed that the inhabitants of campamentos 'live in a situation of informality, not illegality [and that] fighting for their housing [also means] fighting for a community' (bakery representative). In those workshops, the relevance of thinking about their own utopia was discussed along with ideas to bring them into existence in a collaborative and feasible manner.

Once the right to the city workshops were finished, the inhabitants of Los Arenales had already co-produced, with ORDHUM's academics and FRACTAL, an urban manifesto and a strategy as their way to bring their concrete utopia into existence where self-sufficient modes of production were central (Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019). The specific interest in forming a cooperative was initially developed by FRACTAL, since a member socialised his experience of visiting mutual aid cooperatives in Argentina. This resonated with several representatives of Los Arenales.

Initially, 'the idea was to start a work cooperative [to] facilitate the building of our own houses [...], but it was too monstrous, too giant' (Los Arenales representative). Nonetheless, that intention was presented to the local FOSIS agency which, despite being initially reluctant, was convinced of funding a cooperative in Los Arenales as 'a space of collective construction' (FOSIS representative), because of its 'strong capacity for self-organisation, [and ability] to articulate itself with several other actors in a highly autonomous way' [FOSIS representative].

To get the funds, the National Director of FOSIS was brought to visit Los Arenales, 'and he [the National Director] almost fainted [because] he told me "this is not the Chile I know"! [he said he] had not seen any campamentos like that in the country, especially with that number of different nationalities [...] and he said "I will get the funds, but you have to organise a sustainable project"' (FOSIS representative).

This led to the fast negotiation and approval of an initial capital of 10.000.000 CLP (around \$14,000 USD), provided by FOSIS for starting a food cooperative but under certain conditions. The whole project had to be finished and running within

six months and FOSIS demanded the signature of an agreement with at least one local university endorsing the project, since ‘despite the good will [...] the [state] institutions were not satisfied with the campamentos [being] in charge [of the project] alone [...] and FRACTAL was [perceived as] too radicalised’ (FOSIS representative). The short deadline was due to the arrival of the recently elected right-wing government, meaning that all the governmental projects had to be completed before the change in administration scheduled for March 2018.

A bakery was chosen since bread is highly symbolic in Latin American cultures,⁹ representing the simple but necessary communal and inalienable struggle to feed the family, especially when facing stark scarcity (Jelin, 1998). In Los Arenales particularly, bread has cultural meaning as a symbol of sustainable livelihoods and dignity (Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019). ‘Here [at Los Arenales] everyone eats bread. Bread is the first plate on the table’, said a bakery representative, explaining that bread production was perceived as profitable and relatively easy and cheap to produce (Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019). The cooperative logic was based on ‘[providing] jobs for people without jobs [in Los Arenales], who are mostly women. But also [the bakery’s] statutes clearly said that 2 per cent of the cooperative profits must go to improving the [built environment of the] macrocampamento’ (Los Arenales representative).

Bread was going to be sold at ‘the lowest prices possible [...] helping people’s pockets’ (bakery representative), specifically, 30 per cent cheaper than the average price in the city. This shows their commitment to achieving sustainable socio-economic goals, contrasting with the profit-driven strategies of traditional capitalistic businesses, notably in neoliberal contexts. The bakery also intended to represent and celebrate the multicultural diversity within Los Arenales, offering Chilean, Colombian, Peruvian and Bolivian bread. Its products were sold based on in-lane sales and delivery throughout the macrocampamento. Consequently, the inhabitants of Los Arenales were excited, as they felt the bakery was a way ‘to become a strong community [by] following our own processes to empower ourselves’ (Los Arenales representative). ‘If this has worked in other places, why not here?’ was remarked in most of the assembly meetings.

For signing the agreement, Los Arenales was represented by the committee Rayito de Esperanza (Little Beam of Hope). Together with FRACTAL, FOSIS, ORDHUM and UST, Los Arenales committed to collaborating in co-producing the bakery. Rompiendo Barreras initiated the process of making a broad call for cooperativists. Twenty neighbours from eight committees participated as the initial cooperativist group, and they agreed to attend the training provided by FRACTAL, UST and ORDHUM. FRACTAL was hired by the bakery to provide training in cooperativism, technical assistance and support during the whole process, which was filmed in a documentary freely available on YouTube (CIPNOR, 2018).

9 Several artists and politicians have encapsulated this feeling in their speeches, songs and poems.

Most of the funds were used to get physical capital and to set up the bakery and supplies. The UST committed forty-five hours of training related to producing bread and other baking-related merchandise by gastronomy specialists. ORDHUM oversaw training related to the basics of how to run a firm, become a technical advisor, and observe the process to leave tangible knowledge for similar projects. Likewise, ORDHUM committed to visualising and provoking a favourable public opinion of the project by writing in local and national newspapers (Arias-Loyola, 2018; Vergara-Perucich, 2018) as ‘militant acts’ (Hoffman, 2019), while the cooperativists gave several interviews about the process. Both the UST and ORDHUM academics worked *ad honorem*. After these preparations, the bakery project officially started in November 2017 with the signing of the multi-actor agreement.

Co-producing bread, resilience and empowerment

The actors lacked experience in cooperative ventures and faced a tight deadline, but recognised the relevance of collective experimentation in bringing ‘a new kind of economy into existence’ (Gibson-Graham, 2008). Rompiendo Barreras and FRACTAL oversaw the legalisation process and administered the funds while the training was planned with ORDHUM and UST. FOSIS limited its participation to supervising the project, ensuring that administrative and financial aspects were in order. Once the new government took office, interactions with FOSIS were reduced to periodic meetings related to achieving goals.

Training began in early 2018, with UST professionals ‘assisting in how to make bread, as a way to build [our] dream’ (cooperative representative) in forty-five teaching hours. However, UST professionals carried out the training ‘by lending [...] their equipment [...] as quietly as possible [...] probably because [Los Arenales] was in a nebula of illegality. So, to [publicly show their participation] was like they were validating that model [of informal settlements]’ (FOSIS representative). Hence, UST’s participation ended with the training, illustrating how practices for developing self-sufficiency in campamentos are frowned upon in some Chilean universities.

Simultaneously, ORDHUM, from the Economics Department of the UCN, started training the cooperativists in the basics of how to run a firm, developing an entrepreneurial attitude and building teamwork, accountability and horizontal working environments. ORDHUM also participated in the co-production of a business model canvas with the trainees from Rompiendo Barreras, volunteer students and FRACTAL and a SWOT analysis presented in Table 2. In parallel, FRACTAL started training about cooperative firms and values. However, the great number of workshops – exceedingly condensed into a few weeks – took a heavy toll since, after a while, the attendance vastly dropped: The fifth workshop organised by ORDHUM had almost no attendance. Understandably, this situation exposed the high opportu-

Table 2 SWOT analysis

STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES
Strong local media presence. Bakery considered as an example of an autonomous entrepreneurial initiative for overcoming poverty in campamentos. Only bakery selling different kinds of bread (Chilean, Colombian and Bolivian). Diversification of the business into catering services. Great will to work. Group's creativity and interest in developing a long-term source of income. Half of the cooperativists are fully committed with the project and have a strong sense of belonging and proud. Support and involvement of FRACTAL, ORDHUM and other institutions that could provide technical assistance, training and visualisation of the project. Great social interest to see this initiative succeeding in the long term.	Lack of staff at some times of the day. Lack of tolerance among some members. Lack of initial capital. Informality of the business. Need of constant source of incomes from the cooperativists. Schedule limitations due to family and/or other commitments. Stark lack of training in both cooperativism and how to run a business. Two opposite views about how to run the business (classic business model v/s cooperativist model) has caused several internal frictions. Part of the group is not committed enough.
OPPORTUNITIES	THREATS
Great interest of local and national media. Great interest of academia. Increasing the variety and quality of products and services provided. Great potential to increase the clients outside the campamento. To participate in a cooperative association. State funds for social entrepreneurial initiatives. Physical new place for installing the bakery definitively. Training options. Access to private loans.	Impossibility of overcoming the informal situation as long as the bakery stays within an informal settlement. Machinery depreciation. Other competitors. Media showing negative view of the campamentos and its inhabitants. Possible legal problems. Possibility of accidents. Associating with people and/or groups that make them lose autonomy.

Source: Authors' own elaboration

nity cost for the trainees, ‘because if you do not have the resources [...] to feed your children, you think twice about attending a full-day workshop’ [bakery representative].

The low attendance was a sign of exhaustion, leading the future cooperativist to discuss stopping the project. In those assemblies, it was common to hear ‘this is all very pretty, but I want to work right now’, interpreted by some as a sign of the ‘embedded individualism, [we were still not] cooperativists in our minds and hearts’

(Los Arenales representative). Nonetheless, when deciding to formalise (or not) the bakery, a cooperativist explained that '[they had] suffered too much [...] struggled too much to leave [the project] like this', deciding 'to make this cooperative work [...] to become a cooperative'. Thus, and against all the odds, the cooperative bakery was inaugurated in March 2018. The initial staff comprised twelve cooperativists – eleven women – who finished their basic training.

The bakery was extremely well received by the local and national press as an example of grassroots-led multi-actor social innovation (Timeline Antofagasta, 2018; TVN 24 Horas Central, 2018). Within five months, it expanded its production to providing catering services, while also changing the name to *Cooperativa de Trabajo Comunidad Internacional de Trabajadoras y Trabajadores CINTRA Los Arenales*.¹⁰ Yet, there were two strong increasingly antagonistic female leaders in the bakery: one championed cooperative values and non-capitalistic production, whereas the other proposed market-based ones, closer to a traditional capitalistic firm. Tensions were high when they had to elect a manager to continue the legal formalisation. Unfortunately, the other actors did not realise how those frictions could influence the bakery project, which they did. The only man was proposed as the manager candidate by one of the female leaders because he was perceived as 'a mediator in that conflict, who was also very committed', per a FRACTAL representative, and a figure projecting 'respect, seriousness and transparency', per a bakery representative.

FRACTAL and ORDHUM failed to mediate the rising conflict properly and to continue providing enough technical assistance to the cooperativists for several reasons, summarised as a heavy underestimation of their time constraints and inexperience (Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019). FRACTAL was simultaneously providing technical support and coordinating the participant actors, which was extremely time- and energy-consuming, especially considering that the NGO also had other commitments. Furthermore, FRACTAL didn't want to take part in the conflict directly, because it was perceived as too close to one of the female leaders. Meanwhile, ORDHUM's team was being criticised and beleaguered by some colleagues, local authorities and NGOs, since the project was considered as a 'waste of academic time'; and a threat to more patronising asymmetrical power relationships between the state, other NGOs and campamento's inhabitants. These issues, along with the high workload of Chilean academics (Guzmán-Valenzuela and Barnett, 2013), distracted the team.

Additionally (and unexpectedly), in early 2018, a participant of the international NGO Slum Dwellers International (SDI) became aware of the cooperative bakery and contacted Rompiendo Barreras to announce their Know Your City (KYC) project expansion for Latin American submissions. KYC is a 'global campaign for participatory, pro-poor, people-centred urban governance' (SDI, 2018, 4), empowering and linking slum dwellers with local governments. Rompiendo Barreras was

10 In English: International Work Cooperative Community of Workers (female and male) CINTRA Los Arenales.

extremely interested and asked FRACTAL and ORDHUM to take part. Rompiendo Barreras, FRACTAL and ORDHUM applied and were awarded 18,500 USD for the first KYC project in Chile. This involved the co-production of primary information such as: participatory mappings; a census; a series of workshops related to housing, solidarity, empowerment and human rights; and a learning-by-doing activity with 150 UCN students involving painting the social heart of the macrocampamento. New actors joined this initiative, adding complexity while reducing time. A new multi-actor agreement was signed, and the KYC project started in July of 2018, whilst the bakery process was finishing its legalisation, and internal tensions peaked.

The lack of more active involvement during this critical time by FRACTAL and ORDHUM left the cooperativists feeling ‘abandoned by them’ [bakery representative]. Without mediating actors, the internal conflicts exploded one week before the deadline for formalising the bakery, meaning that ‘it was possible that FOSIS could take the machines back, [so] all the work was going to be lost’ (FRACTAL representative). This caused a break between the bakery management and FRACTAL, splitting the bakery into two groups: one supporting the management, comfortable with vertical working relationships and focused on achieving better wages and product diversification; and another proposing horizontal cooperative values, decent wages and reinvestment of profits in the macrocampamento’s built environment, and who then abandoned the project.

A member of ORDHUM mediated to ‘defuse tensions [...] but it was too late, the two sides were very antagonistic’ (ORDHUM representative). By the end of 2018, the bakery was formally producing with just six people (half of the initial group) and had stopped catering services. Starting in 2019, bread was occasionally produced by only three women from the ‘cooperative’ group, who came back and partially reactivated bread production, since the manager and his supporters had moved on to other entrepreneurship. After some weeks, the bakery finally stopped production for a brief time to evaluate the process.

Even though it was perceived as a big defeat, the struggle for a piece of the concrete utopia through the cooperative bakery was not over for Los Arenales. The hiatus allowed at least four cooperativists to ‘meet with other people, to read more about cooperativism and to teach those [learnings] to other neighbours’ (bakery cooperativist). Likewise, they travelled as guests to talk about the experience and widen their networks and knowledge. This led four of them to decide to resume the cooperative production, incorporating two members of FRACTAL ‘to complete the six people required [...] by FOSIS [to finish the legalisation process]’ (bakery cooperativist). They changed the name but kept the acronym CINTRA Los Arenales, which currently means Cooperativa Intercultural de Trabajo.¹¹ As a bakery cooperativist stated: ‘We started to work again and now [the cooperative bakery] is legalised [...]

11 In English: Intercultural Working Cooperative.

we also have permission to work in three things: bakery/catering [...], recycling and teaching, [the latter] since we are already trained [...] in cooperativism as a form of solidarity, respect, equality and social justice’.

This new bakery will comprise an initial group of six cooperativists and share space with La Casita to ‘get the sanitary permissions, and to be [between] the campamento and formal neighbourhood’ (bakery cooperativist). Its diversification intends to increasingly incorporate more inhabitants from Los Arenales as cooperativists and to keep reinvesting in the macrocampamento, showing the great resilience of its members. When asked to evaluate the whole experience, a cooperativist explained:

The bakery was the start of everything, but [during the process] I understood that a cooperative is a pearl that not everyone can have [...] it is a process of listening [...], of deciding [...], of organising ourselves in the assemblies [to form] collective spaces and self-management. [Initially] we did not realise that, in order to make the cooperative work in such a large space as the macrocampamento [...], we needed mutual trust, which we didn’t have [at the time].

The challenging co-producing of the bakery, mutual support and honesty (despite the flaws and fair criticism) led Los Arenales to build reciprocal trust with FRACTAL and ORDHUM, crystallised in the KYC project. That project was a larger, deeper and more complex multipartite effort to bring Los Arenales’s concrete utopia closer, as well as to bring inputs for their struggle for their right to the city. Therefore, the cooperative bakery ‘was the complement of the SDI project. We [as a tripartite group] adventured in an experience [...] without understanding how big it was [...]. Those empowering processes [bakery and KYC] allowed us to realise we have the capacities [for planning our urban spaces] and start bargaining [their production]’ (Los Arenales representative).

When critically evaluating this period, FRACTAL recognises that ‘we could have done more, especially when we had the conflict completely identified’ (FRACTAL representative). However, they also acknowledge the crucial value of the co-produced lessons about:

what can work out and which things should be done. What are the times required and how each people’s particularities and groups are paving the way [to success] [...]. The fact that there were people with different nationalities, life trajectories and culture can be great contributions, but it can also produce tensions [...]. This was clearly a failed project [but left valuable lessons] for helping future projects in avoiding failure [...] [more importantly], cooperatives are a way through which certain members of the community are considering to build and collectively appropriate the land [...] in a solidary political effort. (Fractal representative)

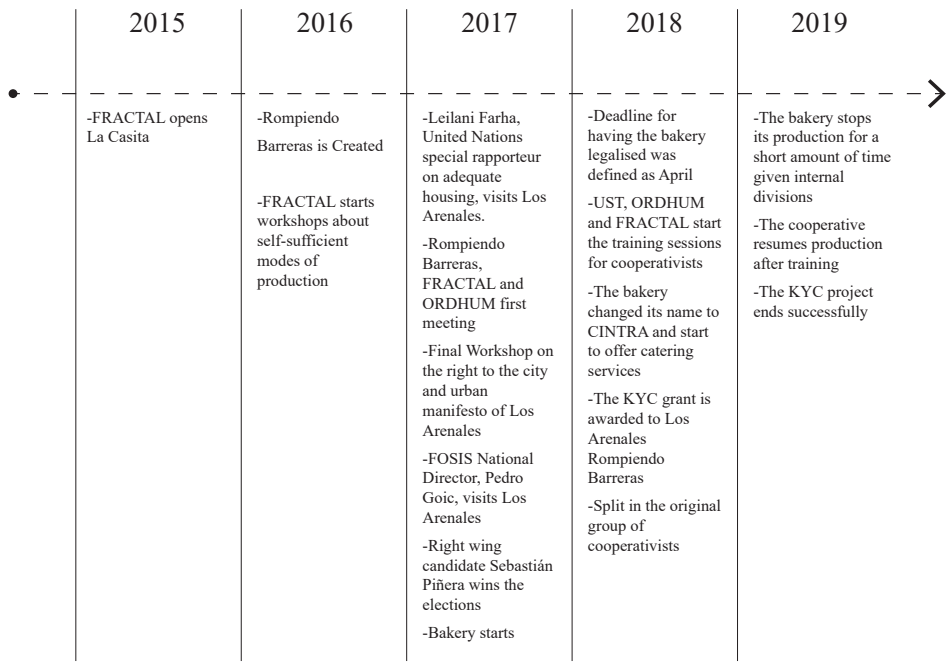


Figure 4 Timeline of main events
Source: Authors’ own elaboration

ORDHUM academics also assessed the experience, acknowledging that the team was passionate about the idea to help the inhabitants of Los Arenales reach their rightful place in the formal city as inhabitants, workers and community. However, the team recognises it was too overconfident and failed to satisfy the project’s needs properly, especially regarding mediating conflicts, but also in training and supervising the cooperativists. The latter was critical since most participants were not familiarised with either running a business or becoming part of a cooperative. The team also acknowledges its underestimation of their time constraints and political frictions caused by the project. Nonetheless, it also recognises that the flawed process

was extremely enriching for everyone involved [...]. None of the people participating ended up being the same as they were before [the process] [...]. Despite all the people saying that it was not possible, it still happened [...]. Several cooperativists ended up really believing in cooperative values [...]. The bakery made Los Arenales visible and more empowered, but also strengthened [their] networks. (ORDHUM representative)

The resilience of the inhabitants of Los Arenales is a force to be reckoned with. The re-opening of the cooperative bakery coincided with the final activities of the KYC project. By this point, the Los Arenales community had also co-produced several participative maps; finished workshops where local, national and international leading experts – even the SDI representative for Latin America – aimed to empower them; and were finishing the questionnaire for the census. The KYC facilitated several representatives from Los Arenales visiting other SDI related activists and the bakery helped them establish links with other cooperatives in Latin America. Their sense of collective empowerment drove them to lead bargains with local and national authorities (like members of the national parliament and local/regional governments) about their *radicación* and progressive implementation of their urban manifesto and imagined utopia. They have also organised several multitudinous manifestations in Antofagasta, becoming crucial actors in the local struggle for the right to the city.

Conclusions

This article presents the extremely experimental co-produced social innovation process of creating the first cooperative bakery in a Chilean macrocampamento as a form of diverse economy for promoting self-sufficiency and urban social justice. This case is relevant since:

- 1) the neoliberal Chilean context has not fostered the apparition of cooperatives nor the funding of projects in informal settlements by the state (Harvey, 2005; Solimano, 2012);
- 2) the actors participating in the various stages of the bakery were markedly disjointed previous to the project;
- 3) Chilean campamentos have been long-term victims of disempowering practices by the state since the dictatorship, leading to precarious living conditions (Handelman, 1975; Salcedo, 2010);
- 4) institutions working in campamentos usually do not foster self-sufficiency (Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola, 2019);
- 5) Chilean universities are focused on scientific production rather than creating better realities for the disadvantaged (Guzmán-Valenzuela and Barnett, 2013);
- 6) campamento's inhabitants and immigrants face strong discrimination, being increasingly expelled to informal settlements (Contreras et al., 2019; Tijoux and Díaz, 2014);
- 7) it provides a critical evaluation of a flawed process, which led to valuable lessons about the right to experiment and fail, and a higher resilience among the actors involved, especially in the Los Arenales community.

It was highly unlikely that a cooperative bakery run by the most socially vulnerable people could survive, but it did, providing significant learning for future experiences in similar contexts.

As the first of its kind, this endeavour involved a considerable amount of trial and error, where the actors heavily underestimated the issues that could arise. Hence, it was fundamentally signalling *the right to fail*, which ensures that the lessons co-produced will inform better failures in the future. This is especially innovative and relevant when co-producing social innovations with the urban poor, who do not have the luxury of continuous experimentation due to their urgent needs. Therefore, public policies must be implemented to lower the cost of failure, ensuring further experimental (co)productions of the desired urban and socio-economic utopic imaginaries *with* and *for* the urban displaced. We consider this as one of the main contributions of this experience.

From the co-producing group's failures in proper training in the basics, lessons can be drawn regarding cooperative modes of production, running a company and acknowledging and mediating the internal tensions that may arise in a highly heterogeneous group. Learning about cooperative modes of production can be more challenging than understanding how to start a regular business, especially in neoliberal contexts, since it implies thinking collectively instead of individually. As a bakery representative explained: 'It is good that you teach us the basics [...] but it is also important to keep reinforcing those lessons [because] sometimes you attend a [...] workshop and learn something, but after a few days, you start forgetting. You should reinforce and add to that knowledge [constantly].'

Thus, workshops should be planned and carried out in a way that the trainees adequately absorb and apply that new knowledge, instead of just squeezing too much into too little time. Those supporting the projects with the appropriate know-how, such as professionals from NGOs, the state and academics, should keep aiding and advising after finishing the training since at this stage, mistakes and frustration can lead to increased friction and dropouts. This also means that providing stress relief by helping with complex responsibilities is imperative, as warned by Castán and Neves (2018).

The conflict exploded when the urgency of securing individual wages for subsistence clashed with cooperative values based on solidarity, causing a break. This could have been avoided if cooperative values were better understood and embraced by participant group, but also with a more active mediation by FRACTAL, ORDHUM and FOSIS. Securing the participation of people with experience in cooperatives could also provide grounded experience about the challenges of the whole process, avoiding its idealisation and unreal expectations. The opportunity cost of the time spent in workshops should also be reduced, either by holding them after paid working hours (e.g. 7.00 pm) or by paying the attendants for their time, meaning that proper funding is central.¹²

12 The cooperativists worked in two shifts: one working from 3.00–6.00 am and another from 2.00–6.00 pm. After the internal break, they were still working during the early morning and sometimes in the afternoons.

However, the horizontal interdependencies implemented between the three main actors (Swyngedouw, 2005) encouraged mutual trust and allowed for their joint participation in the first KYC project. These two projects have made Los Arenales highly visible, empowered and admired since, as the most stigmatised inhabitants of Antofagasta they managed to start the first cooperative bakery and win the SDI-funded project in Chile. The workshops that were conducted in both projects gave rise to several, and mostly female, new leadership figures within the macrocampamento and a sense of pride and hope about getting the *radicación*. Between 2017 and 2019, the inhabitants of Los Arenales and the bakery's cooperativists became recognised activists and travelled abroad for international meetings, training sessions and conferences, which widened their networks.

Despite its flaws, the participant group – and especially the inhabitants of Los Arenales – consider the bakery to have improved their quality of life and made them visible, more respected and more resilient. They are keen to continue their experimentation with horizontal multi-actor and communal forms of organisations to bring their desired utopia closer to being achieved. This means that the bakery can be considered a desirable social innovation. Representatives of Los Arenales are now leading the local campamentos' struggle for their right to the city, but are also participating in the feminist and immigrant movements. They have increasing support from civil society organisations, national and international academics, international activists and members of parliament. They have even had meetings with the Ministry of Housing of Chile, about the *radicación* of campamentos (El Regionalista, 2019). Hence, they became a beacon for other urban displaced people and a symbol of resilience, who are also reaching out to universities and NGOs to explore new diverse economies aimed at their self-sufficiency and emancipation. As a final reflection, a representative of Los Arenales claims:

[Before the bakery and the KYC] when we had a [general] meeting, no one wanted to [attend] because they were scared that something might happen to them while walking to the meeting. But then, [the neighbours] slowly started to know each other, and realised we all have the same problems [which increased] the degree of trust [...] and in believing more in our struggle [for a dignified life] [...] [These projects] have allowed us to become an organisation of dwellers, to dream about having dignified and fair housing [...] [because when bargaining with the state] I say [we] learned from the best, the best people say this is viable, not only from here, but also from Santiago and other countries and universities [...]. We demand to participate [in deciding about our city] [...] these are the proofs [KYC products], these are the ways [...] and they [government representatives] sit in shock.

When singing about *Los Arenales*, Skimi considers its inhabitants: 'Like cactuses growing in the sand without being seen, transforming the ideas and getting rid of

the stigmas [...] we have to show at the national level what we are really capable of, people capable of triumphing' ('Como Átomos'). These words highlights the fundamental relevance of the right to experiment and fail, in order to foster social innovations for better – and just – futures for the urban poor. For the co-producing group, such triumphs are built on potential failures, or progression through struggle – as Los Arenales did –, by choosing to keep trying, failing better, no matter what.

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